completely, not knowing that a kiss, her first, could last so long. *Let us stay like this forever*.

When the movie ended, the lights came on. Smoothing her dress, Rose felt changed. She was no longer the woman she'd been upon entering the cinema. André was still holding her hand as they stood. He hadn't let go of it, and she was sure he never would. Slightly jittery, she felt at peace. There was no one else like him, this man who had steered her to safety in the Café du Marché, engaged with her art, believed in her dreams, and respected and understood her closeness to Léa. The moment he entered her life, Rose's world changed. With André, she felt alive and able to see past the war's darkness to a brighter future together.

Hand in hand, they walked along the row. He went ahead, blocking her view of the aisle. She wanted to remember this moment, the feelings swirling inside. But then she felt him hesitate, and in the next instant, he let go of her hand.

At the door, two gendarmes were checking identity papers. André stepped away from her and, once he was free of the aisle, made his way to the emergency exit. Rose, sensing danger like a swift-moving storm, willed him to hurry, though knowing he mustn't draw the attention of the gendarmes. A swish of blue. Her legs shook.

"*Vos papiers, monsieur*."

Trickles of sweat slid down her back as she watched André pat his pockets. Surely, he wouldn't surrender his papers.

"*Mince*, looks like I've forgotten them," he said.

The gendarme whistled to his colleague, who came over and attached handcuffs to André's wrists. "Come to the station and we'll check your papers there."

A part of her wanted to believe he'd figure a way out, that he was too clever and strong, that he'd escape and be back with her tomorrow, but another part knew that the gendarmes had come to the cinema to hunt men like him. He was trapped.

In a way, it was her fault. She should have urged him to avoid the center of town; the risk wasn't worth it. He'd dropped her hand to protect her because whatever suspicion had fallen on him could pass to her if the gendarmes believed they were together.

Rose's chest burned but she forced herself to do what André would want